

Lab - Using Shellbags to View Hidden or Deleted Folders

Overview

In this lab, you will learn how to retrieve information on archived items, even after the folders have been deleted or the external drive has been disconnected from a suspect's machine.

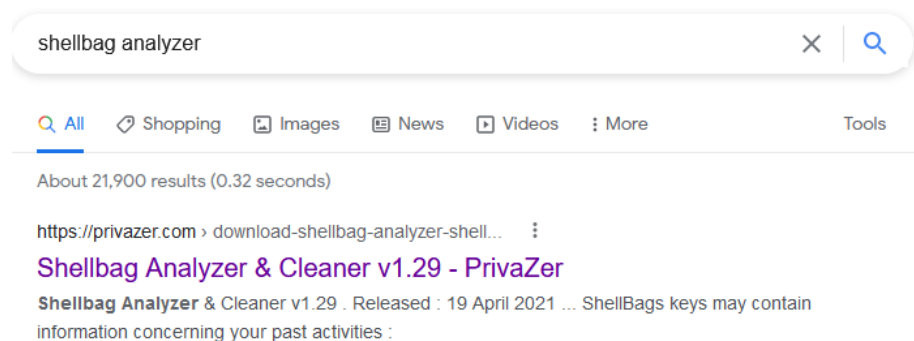
Starting with Windows 7, Microsoft Windows provides the ability for the operating system to track user window viewing preferences specific to Windows Explorer. This information, called "ShellBag" information, is stored in several locations within the Windows Registry in the Windows Operating System.

Shellbags maintain the information for folders even after the directory is removed, which means they could be used as a forensic method to snoop on deleted files, folders, and specific user actions.

Since the ShellBag registry subkeys store various metadata on how Windows File Explorer items were arranged, and since they are recorded for each user, from a computer forensics standpoint, one can parse the data and pull-out various pieces of information that relate to user interaction. For example, when combined with other available computer artifacts, it could provide a complete picture of what files were accessed or deleted by the user and from what storage device they were being accessed from (could be either an internal, external, or network storage device or even a phone that was once attached to the PC).

Lab Requirements

- One install of Windows 7 or Windows 10.
- Download and run **Shellbag Analyzer & Cleaner** from PrivaZer.



Next screen.

<https://privazer.com/en/download-shellbag-analyzer-shellbag-cleaner.php>

Shellbag Analyzer & Cleaner v1.29

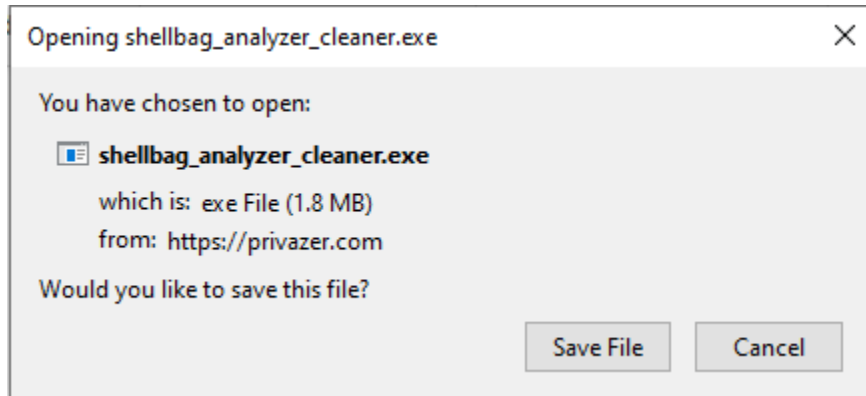
Download

Released : **19 April 2021**

Compatible : XP, Vista, Win7, Win8/8.1, **Win10**, 32bits & 64bits

Compatible : HDD and SSD

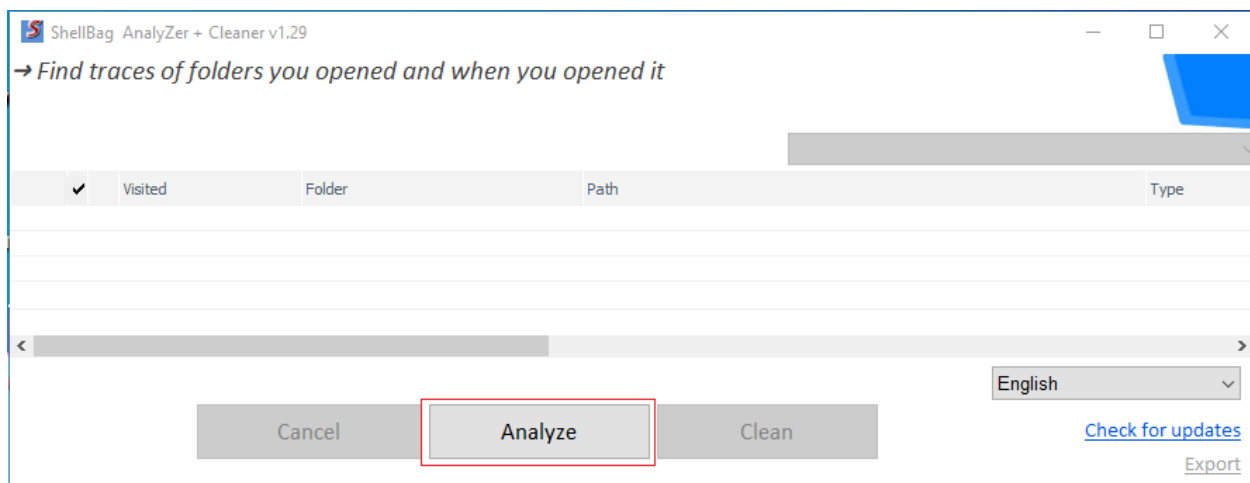
Download and save the file to your local machine.



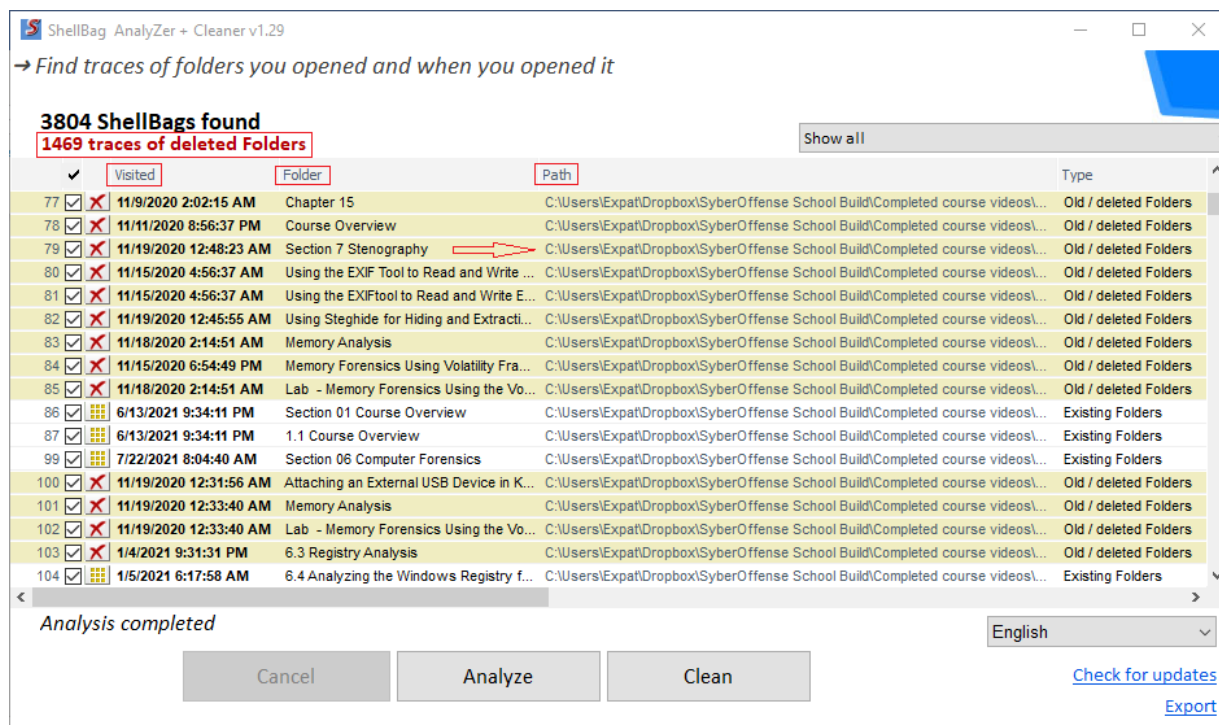
Shellbag Analyzer & Cleaner requires no installation meaning you can run the program from an external thumb drive or a network share.

Begin the lab!

Find your download and launch. Click, Analyze.



Once the analysis is complete, you will be shown all the shellbags on the machine to include any deleted folders, the date last visited, the folder location, and the path where the folder was located before it was deleted.



From the above analysis of my workstation, you can see the history of every deleted file since the Shellbags were last cleaned, which in this case, has never happened. Thus, you can see that even though the user may have attempted to delete the evidence, we still have proof that the file, be it malware or an Excel spreadsheet, did exist on the machine at one time.

Summary

We learned how to use shellbags to view hidden and deleted files on a Windows machine in this short lab, starting with Windows 7.